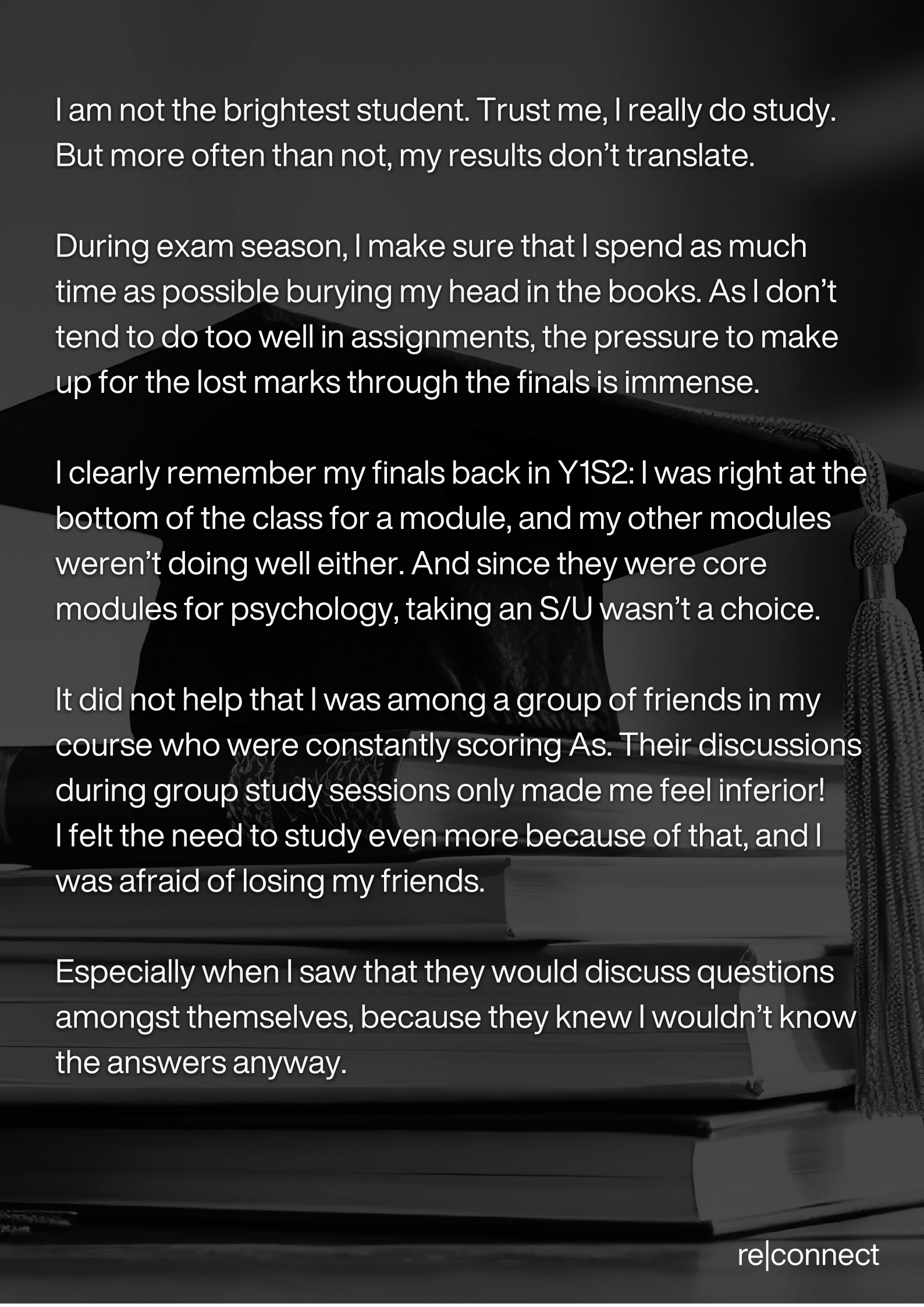




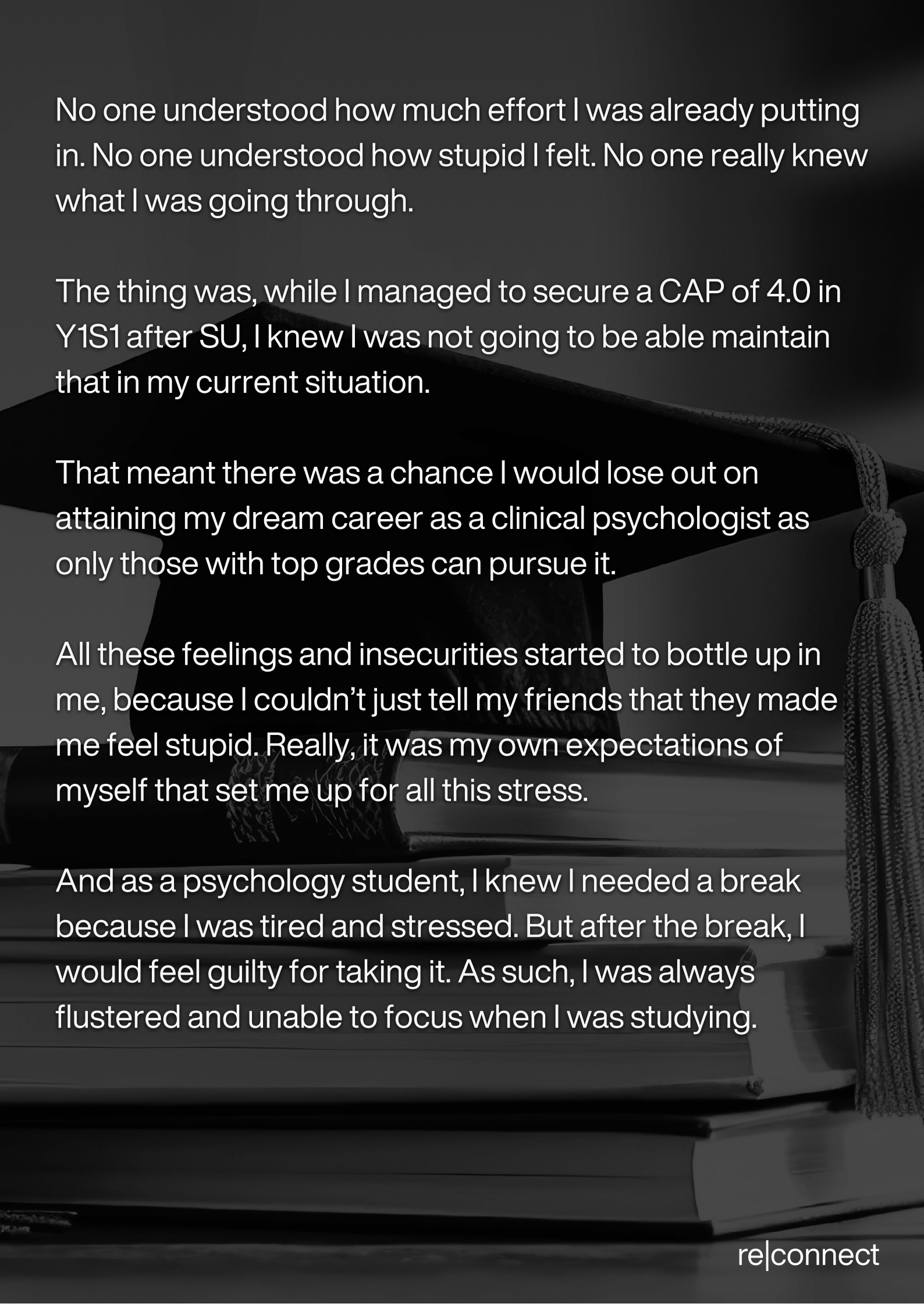
I am not the brightest student. Trust me, I really do study. But more often than not, my results don't translate.

During exam season, I make sure that I spend as much time as possible burying my head in the books. As I don't tend to do too well in assignments, the pressure to make up for the lost marks through the finals is immense.

I clearly remember my finals back in Y1S2: I was right at the bottom of the class for a module, and my other modules weren't doing well either. And since they were core modules for psychology, taking an S/U wasn't a choice.

It did not help that I was among a group of friends in my course who were constantly scoring As. Their discussions during group study sessions only made me feel inferior! I felt the need to study even more because of that, and I was afraid of losing my friends.

Especially when I saw that they would discuss questions amongst themselves, because they knew I wouldn't know the answers anyway.



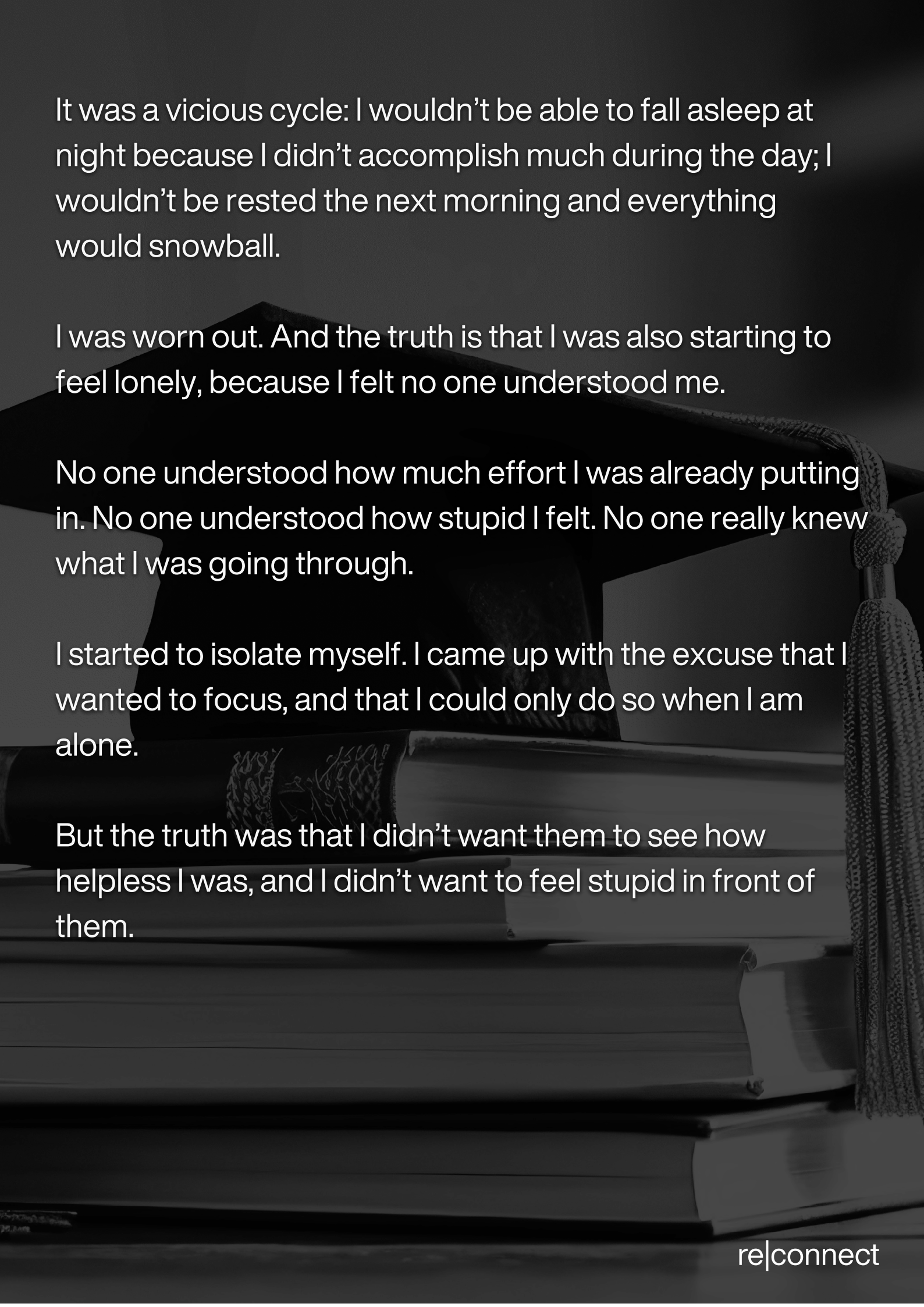
No one understood how much effort I was already putting in. No one understood how stupid I felt. No one really knew what I was going through.

The thing was, while I managed to secure a CAP of 4.0 in Y1S1 after SU, I knew I was not going to be able maintain that in my current situation.

That meant there was a chance I would lose out on attaining my dream career as a clinical psychologist as only those with top grades can pursue it.

All these feelings and insecurities started to bottle up in me, because I couldn't just tell my friends that they made me feel stupid. Really, it was my own expectations of myself that set me up for all this stress.

And as a psychology student, I knew I needed a break because I was tired and stressed. But after the break, I would feel guilty for taking it. As such, I was always flustered and unable to focus when I was studying.

A black and white photograph of a graduation cap and a stack of books. The cap is on the right side of the image, with its tassel hanging down. The books are stacked horizontally, with the spines facing left. The background is dark and out of focus.

It was a vicious cycle: I wouldn't be able to fall asleep at night because I didn't accomplish much during the day; I wouldn't be rested the next morning and everything would snowball.

I was worn out. And the truth is that I was also starting to feel lonely, because I felt no one understood me.

No one understood how much effort I was already putting in. No one understood how stupid I felt. No one really knew what I was going through.

I started to isolate myself. I came up with the excuse that I wanted to focus, and that I could only do so when I am alone.

But the truth was that I didn't want them to see how helpless I was, and I didn't want to feel stupid in front of them.